ÖSTERREICHISCHE NATIONALE WAHLSTUDIE

universität wien
Department of Government

FWF Der Wissenschaftsfonds.

AUTNES Content Analysis of Party Press Releases 2002–2017

Coding procedure & overview of variables

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Vienna, October 2020

Content

Introduction 3
Conditions of use 4
Coding procedure 5
year 7
coder 7
ots_id 7
date 7
v0 party 7
v1 sender 7
v2 keywords 7
v3 title 8
v4 subtitle 8
v5 text 8
v6 subject 1: name 8
v7 subject 1: organisation 8
v8 subject 2: name 8
v9 subject 2: organisation 8
v10 subject_record 8
v11 title: issue 9
v12 title: issue predicate 9
v13 title: reference to EU 9
v14 subtitle: issue 9
v15 subtitle: issue predicate 9
v16 subtitle: reference to EU 9
v17 justification 10
v18 object 1: name 11
v19 object 1: organisation 11
v20 object 1: predicate 11
v21 object 1: record 11
v22 object 1: attribute 11
v23 object 2: name 12
v24 object 2: organisation 12
v25 object 2: predicate 12
v26 object 2: record 12
v27 object 2: attribute 12
v28 object 3: name 12
v29 object 3: organisation 12
v30 object 3: predicate 12
v31 object 3: record 12
v32 object 3: attribute 12
v33 trigger: arena 13
v34 trigger: name 13
v35 trigger: organisation 13
v36 bipartisan press release 13

Introduction

This document describes the coding of party press releases by the Austrian National Election Study (AUTNES), a National Research Network funded by the Austrian Science Fund (FWF) (grant no. S10903-G11) and the Federal Ministry of Education, Science and Research (BMBWF) within the framework of the Austrian Cooperative Infrastructure for Electoral Research (ACIER). The document contains an outline of the coding procedure and an overview of all variables. Inquiries on further details regarding the data and coding can be directed at Laurenz Ennser-Jedenastik (laurenz.ennser@univie.ac.at) at the University of Vienna's Department of Government.

How to cite these data:

Data users are kindly asked to acknowledge the data *and* the accompanying release document. Please refer to the AUSSDA data catalogue (https://data.aussda.at/, doi: 10.11587/25P2WR) for a recommendation on how to cite the data and the documentation.

Conditions of use

Restrictions

The data are available under the terms listed at the AUSSDA Dataverse.

Confidentiality

AUTNES, the Principal Investigators and the funding institutions bear no responsibility for the use of the data, or for interpretations or inferences based on their use, neither do they accept liability for indirect, consequential or incidental damages or losses arising from use of the data.

Deposit requirement

In order to facilitate exchanges within the scientific community and to provide funding agencies with essential information about use of archival resources users of the AUTNES data are requested to notify the AUTNES team of all forms of publications making use of AUTNES data.

Coding procedure

The AUTNES coding of party press releases covers all press releases that were issued by relevant parties (those gaining at least two percent of the vote) in the six weeks prior to the election. All press releases in Austria are delivered to newspapers and broadcasters through a centralised system run by the Austria Press Agency (APA), which makes press releases a highly effective communication tool.

Out of all press releases issued during the last six weeks of the campaign (which we obtained through APA Online Manager and www.ots.at) we pre-select those that were sent out by parties (including regional branches, parliamentary caucuses, and ancillary organisations).

These press releases were then presented to coders who discarded all messages issued by very marginal party actors, as well as press releases containing only technical information on campaign events, audio or video content. The remaining set of *relevant senders* comprises all candidates for the election, government ministers (including in the *Länder*), members of parliament, party officers at the national level, as well as collective actors such as the party organisations themselves and party sub-organisations for women, youth, and the elderly. Only messages from a sender defined as relevant were coded.

The coding procedure applies the AUTNES schema of subjects, predicates, and objects to press releases. The subject is the person or party that features as the conveyor of the message in the title of the press release. Coders record the subject's name (if an individual is present) and his or her party affiliation. If no individual can be identified as the sender in the title of the press release, only the party that issued the press release is recorded as the subject. Up to two subjects are coded.

There are two types of objects: issues and object actors. Issues are recorded by coders selecting from the AUTNES issue coding scheme the one issue that fits the content of the press release's title best. The issue predicate indicates whether the subject's position towards the issue is one of support (+1), rejection (-1), or conveys a neutral/ambivalent stance (0). This procedure (coding of predicate and issue) is repeated for the subtitle of the press release. Also, coders record whether the issue mentioned in the title refers to policy at the European Union level.

Up to three object actors are recorded from the information in the title of the press release, each with their name (if an individual is present) and organisational affiliation. The list of object actors includes mostly politicians and parties, but also other actors such as EU institutions, journalists, NGOs, or foreign governments. Up to three object actor predicates categorise the relation between the subject and each object actor as support (+1), criticism/rejection (-1), or neutral (0).

In addition to the basic subject-predicate-object structure we code four more variables for the years 2002 to 2013: attributes for all object actors, party records for all subject and object actors, justifications for issue statements, and the incident that triggered the press release. Coders may use information from the title, subtitle, and the first paragraph of the press release for these variables.

Attributes are recorded for all object actors that meet the criteria for 'relevant senders' (see above). We use five categories, each with a positive or negative sign: competence (+/-), leadership qualities (+/-), character (+/-), appearance (+/-), and a residual category (+/-).

Party records are coded if the subject in the press release refers his/her own or an opponent's past behaviour (most typically government politicians praising their policy achievements, or opposition parties criticising governments for policy failures, misconduct, or scandals). Three categories are used: no record, record related to the issue coded from the title, record unrelated to issue coded from the title. Again, records are only coded for actors that fit the criteria for 'relevant sender' (see above).

Justifications are coded if subject actors give specific reasons for the issue positions coded from the title. For instance, an actor may argue for EU membership based on an economic rationale (e.g. benefits from increased trade), whereas another may take the same issue position but justify it based on more universal principles (e.g. peace and stability in Europe). These justifications are recorded in eleven categories: economy, welfare (expansion), welfare (retrenchment), protection of the environment, security, education, governance, ethnic-nationalist, religious, universalistic, plus a residual category.

For the *trigger variables* we record the event that can most plausibly be described as having triggered the press release. It is typically the last element in the causal chain that leads to the writing of the press release. For instance, politicians often respond to actions or statements by their opponents, or to some recent political event (e.g. a parliamentary debate, an international or EU summit, a campaign rally, or a televised debate between party leaders). These are the events that are recorded as triggers of the press release. First, the arena of that event is coded into one of six categories: not classifiable, media, government, international politics (including the EU), party, and other. The first category ('not classifiable) is used when politicians respond to statements by other politicians without making explicit in which context these statements were made. Second, if present, we record the actor (individual or collective) that is associated with the event (thus the person making a statement or undertaking some action). For individuals, name and organisational affiliation are recorded.

year

- *Description:* This variable entails the year of the respective electoral campaign.
- *Type:* numeric

coder

- *Description:* ID to identify the coder of the press release.
- *Type:* string

ots_id

- *Description:* ID to identify individual press releases.
- *Type:* string

date

- *Description:* Date the press release was released.
- *Type:* date

v0 party

- *Description:* This variable entails the party authoring the press release.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of organisations
  - (1100000) Social Democratic Party of Austria (SPÖ)
  - (1200000) Austrian People's Party (ÖVP)
  - (1300000) Freedom Party of Austria (FPÖ)
  - (1400000) Austrian Green Party (Greens)
  - (1500000) Alliance for the Future of Austria (BZÖ)
  - (1600000) Team Stronach
  - (1700000) Citizens' Forum Austria ('Liste Fritz')
  - (1800000) Communist Party of Austria (KPÖ)
  - (1900000) Liberal Forum (LIF)
  - (2400000) NEOS - The New Austria and Liberal Forum
  - (2500000) EU Exit Party for Austria (EUAUS)
  - (2700000) JETZT - Pilz List

v1 sender

- *Description:* This variable records the three-letter APA channel through which the press release was sent.
- *Type:* string

v2 keywords

- *Description:* This variable entails the keywords of the press release.
- *Type:* string

v3 title

- *Description:* This variable entails the title of the press release.
- *Type:* string

v4 subtitle

- *Description:* This variable entails the subtitle of the press release.
- *Type:* string

v5 text

- *Description:* This variable entails the wording of the press release.
- *Type:* string

v6 subject 1: name

- *Description:* Name of first subject actor.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of individuals
    - (1) no individual actor

v7 subject 1: organisation

- *Description:* Organisational affiliation of first subject actor.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of organisations

v8 subject 2: name

- *Description:* Name of second subject actor.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of individuals
    - (1) no individual actor

v9 subject 2: organisation

- *Description:* Organisational affiliation of second subject actor.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of organisations

v10 subject_record

- *Description:* Reference to subject actor's record.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (0) no record
    - (1) record referring to issue in title (v11)
    - (2) record not referring to issue in title (v11)

v11 title: issue

- *Description:* Coded issue of the title.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of issues
    - (99999) not classifiable

v12 title: issue predicate

- *Description:* Position towards the coded issue of the title.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (-1) rejection/criticism
    - (0) neutral
    - (1) support

v13 title: reference to EU

- *Description:* Does the title refer to regulation of the issue coded in v11 on the European level?
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (0) no reference to EU
    - (1) reference to EU

v14 subtitle: issue

- *Description:* Coded issue of the subtitle.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of issues
    - (99999) not classifiable

v15 subtitle: issue predicate

- *Description:* Position towards the coded issue of the subtitle.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (-1) rejection/criticism
    - (0) neutral
    - (1) support

v16 subtitle: reference to EU

- *Description:* Does the subtitle refer to regulation of the issue coded in v14 on the European level?
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (0) no reference to EU
    - (1) reference to EU

v17 justification

- *Description:* Justification of the issue coded in v11.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (1) no justification
    - (2) economy
    - (3) welfare state: expansive
    - (4) welfare state: protective
    - (5) environment
    - (6) security
    - (7) education
    - (8) governance
    - (9) ethnic-national
    - (10) religious
    - (11) universalistic
    - (12) not classifiable

v18 object 1: name

- *Description:* Name of first object actor.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of individuals
    - (1) no individual actor

v19 object 1: organisation

- *Description:* Organisational affiliation of the first object actor.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of organisations

v20 object 1: predicate

- *Description:* Relation of the subject actor coded towards first the object actor.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (-1) rejection/criticism
    - (0) neutral
    - (1) support

v21 object 1: record

- *Description:* Reference to first object actor's record.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (0) no record
    - (1) record referring to issue in title (v11)
    - (2) record not referring to issue in title (v11)

v22 object 1: attribute

- *Description:* Reference to first object actor's attributes.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (1) no attribute
    - (2) competence: +
    - (3) competence: –
    - (4) character: +
    - (5) character: –
    - (6) leadership: +
    - (7) leadership: –
    - (8) appearance: +
    - (9) appearance: –
    - (10) not classifiable: +
    - (11) not classifiable: –

The variables v23 to v32 are coded with the same categories as the variables v18 to v22:

v23 object 2: name

v24 object 2: organisation

v25 object 2: predicate

v26 object 2: record

v27 object 2: attribute

v28 object 3: name

v29 object 3: organisation

v30 object 3: predicate

v31 object 3: record

v32 object 3: attribute

v33 trigger: arena

- *Description:* Indicates in which arena the press release was triggered.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (1) no trigger present/mentioned
    - (2) arena not classifiable (actor present)
    - (3) media
    - (4) government
    - (5) international
    - (6) party
    - (7) other arena

v34 trigger: name

- *Description:* Indicates which individual triggered the press release.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of individuals
    - (1) no individual actor

v35 trigger: organisation

- *Description:* Organisational affiliation of the individual who triggered the press release.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of organisations

v36 bipartisan press release

- *Description:* Indicates whether the press release was issued by politicians from two different parties. This happens only on extremely rare occasions.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (0) single party
    - (1) bipartisan